

Chapter 2

Stages of Groups, Group Process, and Therapeutic Forces

The literature on group counseling frequently addresses three aspects: stages of group, group dynamics or group process, and therapeutic forces. In this text, the terms *group process* and *group dynamics* refer to the attitudes and interaction of group members and leaders. Writers sometimes define these terms differently, but all agree that they are similar. We agree with Posthuma (2002) who states, "Because of this concurrent, intimate, and ongoing relationship between the two, the two terms can be used interchangeably to mean the same thing" (p. 7). *Therapeutic forces* are the factors that influence the group dynamics. In this chapter, we discuss the importance of understanding each of these aspects of group counseling and how they are interrelated.

Stages of Groups

Much has been written regarding the stages of groups, the characteristics of each stage, and how much time each stage takes (Corey, 2012; Gladding, 2012; Yalom, 2005). However, some of the literature can become confusing when the more detailed description of stages is applied to certain groups, such as discussion, education, or task groups. Our description of stages applies to any kind of group.

All groups go through three stages, regardless of the type of group or style of leadership: the *beginning* stage; the *middle*, or *working*, stage; and the *ending*, or

closing, stage. Whether a group meets for one session or fifteen sessions, it will go through these stages; it is important that the leader attend to each.

The Beginning Stage

The *beginning* stage refers to the time period used for introductions and for discussion of such topics as the purpose of the group, what to expect, fears, group rules, comfort levels, and the content of the group. In this stage, members are checking out other members and their own level of comfort with sharing in the group. For some groups, such as certain task, education, and discussion groups whose topics or agendas have not been predetermined, this is the period when the members determine the focus of the group.

The beginning stage may last part of the first session, the entire first session, or the first couple of sessions. It is common for the members of certain groups to take more than two sessions to feel enough trust and comfort to share beyond the surface level. For instance, it may take groups in a prison or residential treatment center for teenagers as many as three sessions to develop an atmosphere that lends itself to productive group work. For groups in a residential setting, "agendas" between members must sometimes be resolved before the group can proceed to the working stage. For groups with a culturally diverse membership, the beginning stage may need to last a couple of sessions or even longer because members may initially be very uncomfortable and awkward when sharing in front of people who are very different from them.

For some groups, the beginning stage lasts only a few minutes because the purpose is clear and the trust and comfort levels are already high. For example, members who meet to share feelings about a recent suicide, death, or disaster can move through the beginning stage in just a few minutes. School counselors leading groups in an educational setting may find that because of the students' comfort levels with the school counselor, the beginning stage can move more quickly. Oftentimes, leaders spend far too long on this stage, conducting icebreakers and talking about group rules and the purpose of the group when these kinds of activities are not needed. A leader who provides very little structure tends to create a group that stays in the beginning stage for several sessions, creating dynamics that could be avoided. On the other hand, we have seen leaders move too quickly into the working stage, causing members to feel uncomfortable and even become angry.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

If you watched the two videos mentioned in Chapter 1, you saw a bad and then a good opening of the beginning stage. You may want to view videos 1.1 and 1.2 again.

The Working Stage

The *middle*, or *working*, stage is the stage of the group when the members focus on the purpose. In this stage, the members learn new material, thoroughly discuss various topics, complete tasks, or engage in personal sharing and therapeutic work. This stage is the time when members benefit from being in a group. During this stage, many different dynamics can occur because the members are interacting in several different ways. The leader must pay particular attention to the interaction patterns and attitudes of the members toward each other and the leader. This is the time when members decide how much they want to get involved or share. If multicultural issues exist in the group, the leader needs to pay close attention to group dynamics because others may misunderstand the members' actions in the group.

The Closing Stage

The *closing*, or *ending*, stage is devoted to terminating the group. During this period, members share what they have learned, how they have changed, and how they plan to use what they have learned. Members also say goodbye and deal with the ending of the group. For some groups, the ending will be an emotional experience, whereas for others the closing will simply mean that the group has done what it was supposed to do. The length of the closing stage will mostly depend on the type of group. Most groups need only one session for this stage.

Other Models of Sequential Stages of Group Development

In the literature, a number of writers have conceptualized the stages of group in different ways. As outlined earlier, our model is a three-stage model: beginning, working, and closing. Corey (2012) offers a six-stage model: formation, orientation, transition, working, consolidation, and follow-up. Corey's first and last stages have to do with leadership functions such as preplanning, screening, and giving follow-up questionnaires to monitor members' development within the group. We agree with Corey that in many groups there is a transition stage. According to Corey, the transition stage is the period when the beginning stage is over but members are not yet ready to share on a highly personal level. Members contribute and interact, but they are still checking things out. Many counseling, therapy, support, and growth groups go through a transition stage. It is important for a leader to recognize that the group is going through a transition stage and refrain from pushing the group ahead too quickly, thereby causing discomfort. An example of the transition stage would be any group in the second or third session where the members are still feeling out the other members. During the transition stage, members talk and share but nothing goes very deep or personal. We call the sharing done during the transition stage "safe sharing."

The transition stage is important in most counseling and therapy groups. A good example of the leader not recognizing the need for the transition stage is bringing up the topic of sex in the second or third session, when the members are still getting comfortable being in a group and sharing personal matters. This topic would be much better received once the members are in the working stage.

Johnson and Johnson (2012) suggest a seven-stage model that explains members' development within a group:

- Defining and structuring procedures
- Conforming to procedures
- Recognizing mutuality and building trust
- Rebelling and differentiating
- Committing to and taking ownership for the goals, procedures, and other members
- Functioning maturely and productively
- Terminating

The Johnson and Johnson model is an expansion of probably the most well-known sequential stage theory, which is put forth by Tuckman (Tuckman, 1965; Tuckman & Jensen, 1977). Tuckman reviewed studies of group development and found that there were five stages: forming, storming, norming, performing, and adjourning. It is important to point out that almost all the studies reviewed by Tuckman were studies where the leader was mainly using an interpersonal, passive leadership model (Johnson & Johnson, 2012). We agree that in groups where leaders offer little structure, groups most likely will go through these stages, but we want to emphasize that most groups should have enough structure to eliminate the need for going through a storming stage.

The *forming* and *norming* stages that Tuckman describes fall within what we are calling the beginning stage—the period where members get comfortable with being in a group and figure out what is expected and what is going to happen. Cohesion and commitment increase during the norming stage (Johnson & Johnson, 2012). The *storming* stage (which is also in our beginning stage and in Corey's transition stage) occurs in groups where there is tension due to the makeup of the group, the commitment of the members, the purpose of the group, and/or the approach of the leader (Gladding, 2012). Many education, discussion, growth, and counseling groups do not have this kind of tension, so there is no need for a storming stage. Leaders who provide too little structure often see their groups go through a storming stage because the members are frustrated due to lack of leadership on the part of the leader. In our view, the more skilled the leader, the less likely there will be a storming stage, because the leader will do what is necessary to reduce the tension in the group. However, in groups where members are forced to come or in groups where the goal may be team building or learning to get along, the storming stage will most definitely be

present. Sometimes leaders want the members to learn to work together, such as in certain task groups and some residential groups, so they more or less precipitate a storming stage by not providing much direction during the early stage of the group.

Corey (2012) and Gladding (2012) describe in detail some of the dynamics that occur during the storming stage. One sign of the storming stage is conflict between members. Testing the leader is often a characteristic of the storming stage. Resistance is another sign that the group is going through a storming stage. The key for leaders is to recognize what is happening. Leaders who use an active, creative approach to groups usually do not create a storming stage. Skilled leaders curtail many of these occurrences by making sure the members clearly understand the purpose of the group, and by making the group valuable, relevant, interesting, and meaningful.

In certain kinds of groups, particularly task groups, there are times when storming is a desired or necessary stage, especially when there are powerful personalities and some disagreement as to how things should be done. Great skill is required to guide the unpredictable interactions among members through the storming period so that members can work together.

Group Process

Group process refers to the interaction and energy exchange between members and leaders, how the leader reacts to the members, and how the members talk to one another and the leader. Sociologists, social psychologists, therapists, and researchers have studied group process. If you are interested in a discussion of the sociological view of group dynamics and a brief history of the study of group dynamics, see Johnson and Johnson (2012).

Dynamics of Interaction Patterns

One of the most important group dynamics to observe is who talks to whom and how often each member speaks. It is usual in the beginning stage of a group for a couple of members to try to dominate. If this occurs, the leader should alter the pattern by using cutting-off and drawing-out skills. Sometimes members fall into the habit of talking only to the leader or selected members instead of to the entire group. The leader will usually want to change this dynamic and get members to address the entire group, because talking only to the leader or a few other members will not lead to group cohesion.

Silent members may or may not create negative group dynamics. In most groups, participation of all members is desirable. When a member is mostly silent, some of the others usually become uncomfortable, especially if this pattern continues for several weeks and the group is a counseling, therapy, or support group. In certain education, discussion, and task groups, the silent member may not produce a negative dynamic because in these groups the members are not usually as sensitive to the silence.

Another pattern for which the leader should watch is that of one member speaking, followed by the leader, then a second member, then the leader, then a third member, then the leader—rather than member-to-member interaction. The leader should avoid establishing a pattern of responding after each member's comment. Group dynamics may also be affected by members' expectations. If members have been in other groups, it is always a good idea to get some sense of how their groups were conducted because they may expect the current group to be the same as their previous one. Also, the leader should be aware at all times of any cultural or gender issues that may be affecting group dynamics.

EXAMPLE

In this example the leader makes the mistake of responding to each member's comment. A more skilled leader would have let more members comment before commenting herself.

SAM: I like my mother, but I don't feel close to her.

LEADER: I hope that gets better for you.

BILL: My mom and I fight all the time. I can't talk to her about anything.

LEADER: So it is hard for you to talk to her.

NAN: I feel that my mom favors my brother but she won't admit it. We have a terrible relationship.

LEADER: So you feel hurt by your mom's favoritism.

Other patterns that the leader wants to look for include the following:

- Members "ganging up" on other members
- Members arguing with each other
- Members discounting each other's suggestions
- Members presenting problems and others trying to rescue them
- Members presenting a problem and the rest of the group giving advice (It is important for the leader to realize that groups are not advice-giving sessions.)

EXAMPLE

The following example demonstrates how allowing members to give advice from their own frame of reference is often not helpful. Sometimes advice and suggestions are beneficial, but often leaders mistakenly let the group turn into an advice-giving session. In this example, the leader should intervene and redirect the discussion.

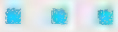
LARRY: ... so I don't know whether to call her or not.

STEVE: I don't think you should call her for at least a week. I like to keep them guessing.

NANCY: I don't know. I think you could wait a week and then send her a nice card.

SANDY: Why not a funny card? I like funny cards from guys.

CRAIG: I personally think you should let her make the next move. Let me tell you what happened to me....



Group Dynamics of Different Kinds of Groups

Any discussion of group dynamics has to take into consideration the kind of group and the leadership style. If the leader does not play an active role, someone in the group will usually try to take the leadership role. Even with an active leader, there can be a bid for control by one or more members. Members may challenge the leader's authority or competency. Throughout the book, we discuss skills for handling these dynamics if they arise. In this section, we discuss dynamics unique to the seven kinds of groups described in Chapter 1.

Education Groups

In an education group, the leader is usually presenting some information. Although the members will probably interact with each other, this is not the most important dynamic. Often, those attending education groups are eager to learn the material being presented. In some education groups, however, the members are not interested in the topic because they have been forced to attend, such as those attending a DUI (driving under the influence) group. In these groups, if the leader does not plan well or is not energetic, the group sessions will, more than likely, not go well.

The dynamics for an education group become difficult when members are at different levels of understanding regarding the subject matter or when some are much more comfortable with the topic than others. The leader of a sex education group must be aware that some members will be more open and comfortable than others. In a group with a diverse population, multicultural issues may create some powerful group dynamics. It is important for the leader to observe how the members are relating to the material and devote extra time if necessary to process any cultural issues.

Education groups usually will not go through long beginning or closing stages. The leader does, however, have to plan for these stages. The middle stage of an education group includes delivery of the content and discussion of the material. As members get to know each other, they usually become more

comfortable and willing to share their reactions, questions, and feelings. The closing stage of an education group usually includes a summary of the material covered.

Discussion Groups

Discussion group leaders primarily need to be aware of any member who tries to dominate or distract the group. Leaders also should pay attention to how comfortable members are in sharing, because if many are not comfortable, only a few members will contribute and a good discussion will not occur. Discussion groups are often led in conjunction with a workshop or class and are, therefore, onetime experiences that last anywhere from 15 minutes to an hour. The tone set at the beginning of a discussion group is usually crucial—the leader should try to set a positive, interactive tone. If possible, the leader should try to get everyone to share something in the first few minutes. This gets members involved and gives the leader an idea of each member's energy for the topic. The closing usually consists of a summary of what was said.

Task Groups

In a task group, the ways in which members interact may be the most important dynamic to monitor. This is especially true if the leader's task is one of team building. Often, task groups accomplish little because the members cannot get along well enough to work together. If this is the case, the leader must do some conflict resolution work or team building before getting to the task of the group. The leader must also be aware of the formation of cliques and plays for power and control.

The beginning stage of task groups is usually brief—the task is clarified and the members move to the working stage. Ideally, most of the group's time is spent in the middle stage—working on the task. When a task group experiences power plays or tension between members, or the members disagree with the stated task, the leader must be skillful in getting the members through the storming stage. The leader may need to use cutting off, structured activities, and maybe sit in on some pairs of members who are in conflict to help ease the tension. The closing stage of a task group can be very brief, sometimes coinciding with accomplishment of the task. However, some task groups require a longer closing stage.

Growth and Experiential Groups

Growth and experiential groups vary greatly. In groups whose purpose is values clarification or self-exploration, the most important dynamic is how the members feel about one another, because they will be sharing their thoughts and feelings. Also, members might become jealous of other members' growth or become angry with the leader and blame her for what they are learning about themselves. In some growth and experiential groups, individual members' needs and expectations

can vary so widely that negative forces are created. If this occurs, the leader should focus on issues and concerns that are relevant to the majority of the members. The leader should also look for members who are not appropriate for the group—members who would be better served in some other group experience or individual counseling.

Struggles for leadership can occur in some experiential groups where the purpose is team building and cooperative interaction. Also, members may form cliques that create antitherapeutic forces. Competition among members may arise and can be a detrimental dynamic. If these dynamics occur, the leader may want to talk to members privately or bring it up in the group. The proper method of dealing with this depends on the dynamics, the intensity, and the purpose of the group. When conducting group exercises, members will sometimes angrily turn on other members or on the leader as a result of frustration with the activity.

The beginning stage of a growth or experiential group usually lasts only one or two sessions, because the leader will probably engage the members in some activities during one or both of these sessions. Most members will get more comfortable as the group progresses, and the working stage will be reached fairly quickly. The closing stage usually lasts no more than one session and consists of people sharing what they have learned about themselves and how they have grown.

Support Groups

In a support group, the leader should create a safe environment where members can share. The leader should also make sure that members feel they have opportunities to share their ideas and concerns with the group and that one member does not dominate. Trust, commitment, and genuine caring of members for one another are important dynamics for this kind of group. When members do not trust one another or there are members who are at odds with each other, the support group is not effective. If these dynamics occur, they must be worked through for the group to succeed, either in private or in front of the group, depending on the nature of the problem. The leader may even need to screen out some members if they are detracting from the supportive purpose of the group.

One other dynamic that is important to watch for is lack of commonality. For instance, a leader might form a group to help students who recently moved to the area and are new to the school. Most of the members probably welcome the support, but a member who is new to the school because she could not get along in her other school and was forced to come to the new school would probably not be a good member of such a support group. A member who is new to the school because he is just returning from a 1-year drug treatment facility may not be good for a support group—his needs may be too great, and individual counseling plus a counseling group or a group for recovering students might be best. For a support group to work, members must feel a common bond.

The beginning stage of a support group usually lasts one to three sessions. During this stage, the sharing is usually not as personal as in the middle stage,

when sharing is more intimate and caring is greater because the members now know each other. The closing of a support group can be an emotional experience for its members. Some may even feel frightened by the loss of the group as a support system. Because of this, the leader must allow plenty of time for terminating the group—maybe as much as two entire sessions.

Counseling and Therapy Groups

In counseling and therapy groups, the leader must be keenly aware of how members feel about each other and the leader. Members may resent others for being too quiet, too open, or too "together." Because members of these groups vary in their degree of mental health, the chances for complex dynamics are much higher than in any other group discussed. To prevent the occurrence of some of the complex dynamics, we advocate screening through individual interviews of potential members whenever possible.

Some leaders mistakenly ignore the dynamics and lead the group as if everyone were comfortable with everyone else. This often results in members being not willing to share personally due to their lack of trust in other members, the leader, or both. Also, one negative or hostile member can create impossible dynamics unless the leader does something to neutralize the effect of this member. The leader can do this privately, which is usually best, or in the group if she sees value in this kind of intervention.

Much skill, knowledge, and courage are needed to lead an effective counseling or therapy group. Because members are dealing with personal issues, attacks on the leader are common. Unfortunately, sometimes the attacks are justified because the leader does not have the knowledge or skills necessary to lead the group but is doing so because it is part of the job. As we say throughout the book, *leaders should not lead groups they are not trained to lead.*

The beginning stage of a counseling or therapy group can last one, two, or three sessions. Although some therapeutic discussion or work will probably be done during these sessions, the members usually will still be warming up to the idea of sharing their problems with others. Depending on the members, the counseling or therapy group may go through a transition stage, in which members are sharing but are still not going into serious personal issues. The leader needs to be aware of these dynamics so that he does not push too much for sharing that is beyond the comfort level of the members; at the same time, the leader will want to make sure the group is productive.

During the working stage, the leader needs to be aware that some members may become uncomfortable because watching others work on personal issues gets them in touch with the pain they are trying to avoid. The leader will want to try to make the group safe but also not so comfortable that members bring up only superficial concerns. Members may also have the tendency to draw attention to other members' issues in order to avoid focusing on themselves.

The closing stage usually lasts one session, although there may be occasions when the leader sees a need to allow more time. The leader should pay careful

attention to members' feelings about ending the group, especially if being in the group has been a very emotional, supportive experience for some members.

Self-Help Groups

Many different dynamics can occur in self-help groups, and without a leader to resolve these dynamics, some groups will not be productive and can even be harmful. We strongly believe in the self-help group and feel that generally these groups are very helpful and supportive. However, we recognize that usually few restrictions exist in these groups and that all kinds of dynamics can arise among the members as a result. If you are involved in setting up self-help groups, you should be aware of several dynamics. Members may attack each other or may try to take over the group. Cliques often form, causing other members to feel excluded. Members may need individual therapy in addition to or instead of a self-help group.

Once self-help groups have formed, they usually are ongoing, with new members coming and others leaving constantly. There is usually no trained leader designated in self-help groups. If you are in charge of establishing a self-help group, you may want to attend the first couple of meetings to ensure that the members get off to a good start. We suggest that you then drop in periodically to see if the group is being productive. Sometimes the groups have strayed far from their intended purpose and need to be redirected. Certain self-help groups, such as AA, have a good deal of structure that has evolved over the years.

Therapeutic Forces

It is important for leaders to realize that they must attend to much more than just the verbal exchange among members. Hansen, Warner, and Smith (1980) describe the "group dynamicist" as a person who closely observes the "potent group currents" that influence the members. Some of these currents are lack of trust, lack of commitment, power plays, conflicts between members, strong alliances between members, and attention-seeking behaviors. Awareness of these forces is essential for good leading. Ohlsen, Horne, and Lawe (1988) describe a number of the forces present in almost any group situation. Members want to (1) feel accepted by the group, (2) know what is expected, (3) feel they belong, and (4) feel safe. When these forces are absent, members tend to be negative, hostile, withdrawn, or apathetic. Negative forces create dynamics that require the leader's attention.

The leader can tune in to some of the group dynamics and therapeutic forces by considering the following questions:

- How does each member feel about being in the group?
- Do the members seem to know what is expected in the group?
- Is each member clear about why he or she is in the group?
- How does each member deal with being in the group?
- Do the members seem to like one another?

- Do the members seem comfortable with one another?
- Do the members have a sense of belonging to the group?
- Do the members seem comfortable with the leader?

The answers to these questions can be very helpful to the group leader in understanding how members are feeling about the group and the leader.

Yalom's Curative Factors

Probably the best-known list of therapeutic forces is set forth by Yalom (2005). He discusses therapeutic forces in terms of *curative factors* operating in groups. Yalom studied counseling and therapy groups based on his interpersonal style of leadership and came up with 11 therapeutic factors that he felt needed to be present for a group to be successful:

- Instillation of hope (feeling hopeful about one's life)
- Universality (realizing others have similar concerns)
- Imparting of information (gaining information about healthy living)
- Altruism (giving to other members)
- Corrective recapitulation of the primary family group (opportunity to experience dynamics similar to early childhood experiences)
- Development of socialization techniques (learning social skills)
- Imitative behavior (modeling positive behaviors from other members)
- Interpersonal learning (learning to interact with others)
- Group cohesiveness (closeness among members)
- Catharsis (expressing feelings never expressed before)
- Existential factors (accepting responsibility for one's life)

Of these factors, we agree that most are essential for a therapy group to be productive. The one that may not always occur is the re-creation of early family dynamics. In our more intrapersonal style of leadership this sometimes occurs, but often it does not. Members do, however, work on personal issues pertaining to their childhood. Yalom's groups were more here-and-now groups, so the re-creation of family dynamics often did occur in his groups.

Jacobs, Schimmel, Masson, and Harvill's 15 Therapeutic Forces

Following are descriptions of 15 forces that we feel the leader should attend to. These forces can be either positive (therapeutic), neutral, or negative (antitherapeutic).

Groups that are not successful have one or more antitherapeutic forces operating. As a way to understand this, think of any group you have ever led or been a member of; then go through the 15 therapeutic forces, considering if the force was positive, neutral, or negative for that group. You will find that, if the group was successful, most of the forces were positive or neutral. If the group was not successful, one or more of the forces were negative. Sometimes a single antitherapeutic force can destroy a group. The 15 forces are as follows:

- Clarity of purpose for both the leader and the members
- Relevance of purpose for the members
- Size of the group
- Length of each session
- Frequency of meetings
- Adequacy of the setting
- Time of day for both the leader and the members
- The leader's attitude
- Closed or open group
- Voluntary or nonvoluntary membership
- Members' level of commitment
- Level of trust among members
- Members' attitudes toward the leader
- The leader's experience and readiness to deal with groups
- Coleadership harmony

Clarity of Purpose

The single most important therapeutic force is clarity of purpose; that is, the leader and the members must clearly understand the purpose of the group. In unsuccessful groups, the leader often is unclear as to the purpose and, thus, confuses the members. For instance, a leader might say the group is educational but spend most of the time doing therapy, or the leader might say the group is for support but spend the majority of the time focusing on one person or on one topic that is not relevant for most of the members. Unfortunately, groups where members are unsure of the purpose are an all too common occurrence. It is important that both the leader and members clearly understand the purpose of the group. Much of Chapter 3 deals with clarity of purpose.

Relevance of Purpose

Not only should the members and leaders be clear regarding the purpose, but also the purpose must be relevant for the members. For members in prison, talking about their future jobs would not be relevant if the members had another 5 years on their prison sentence—a more relevant topic would be getting

the most out of prison or getting along with others in prison. For those on the verge of dropping out of school, it would not be relevant to discuss how to study for math and history tests. A better topic would be attitude about school and their plans should they drop out of school. Some leaders have to use prepared materials and there are times when these materials are not relevant for the members.

Group Size

Group size can definitely affect group dynamics, so the leader should pay close attention to the decision of how many members to have in the group. The size of the group will depend in part on its purpose, the length of time of each session, the setting available, and the experience of the leader. We suggest 5 to 8 as the ideal number of members for most groups. For groups with members from very diverse cultural backgrounds, the leader and members may be more comfortable with groups of no more than 5.

If the group is going to meet for 1 hour or less, the leader should keep the group relatively small (no more than 6), unless it is an education group. Education groups usually have from 5 to 15 members; discussion groups usually have from 5 to 8. Ideally, personal growth, support, and counseling or therapy groups have from 5 to 8 members, although there can be as few as 3 and as many as 12.

The size of the group can definitely be antitherapeutic. If the group is too large, members very often hesitate to share or do not have time to share. Leaders form large groups out of necessity without realizing that an antitherapeutic force is being created. Groups that are too small can cause members to feel too much pressure to participate, creating an equally negative force. On the other hand, some small groups (two or three members) with a specific focus, such as on members who attempted suicide or members who had been raped, can sometimes be quite valuable.

Length of Each Session

For members to feel invested in the group and in one another, enough time must be allotted for each session. If a group session is not long enough, members may feel they did not get their chance to share. Another problem that arises when insufficient time is allowed is that the group never really accomplishes much and the sharing never gets very personal. For education, discussion, and task groups, the usual session lasts from 1 to 2 hours; it can be longer in certain instances. Groups in schools usually last a class period, which is 40 to 50 minutes. For groups composed of younger children, the length of time may be much shorter; 30 to 45 minutes is usually a good duration. For therapy, support, and growth groups, at least 1½ hours—and usually not longer than 3 hours—is advisable. However, there may be times when the leader and members decide to meet for a more extended period—5 or 6 hours or for as long as 16 hours.

Frequency of Meetings

The number of meetings per month depends on many different factors, the most important being the purpose of the group and the composition of the members. Groups in residential settings often meet daily or two to three times a week. Most outpatient groups meet once a week or once every 2 weeks. Support groups usually meet once or twice a month. The key to the frequency of meetings is that they not be so frequent that they become boring and not so infrequent that each meeting is like a first session. A leader should pay attention to the effect of the interval between sessions and, if at all possible, adjust the frequency so that it is a positive rather than negative force.

Adequacy of the Setting

There are a number of things to consider regarding where the group meets. One is convenience. Members will tend to come regularly if the location is easily accessible. Of course, the choice of location is not always within the leader's control; but when it is, the leader should consider the convenience factor.

Another consideration is the privacy of the meeting room. Ideally, the group will meet in a room that is closed to any other traffic during the meeting time. Sometimes, especially in schools and some institutions, this is not possible. When faced with an inadequate setting, the leader must do as much as possible to ensure privacy, recognizing that an antitherapeutic force is operating.

The leader should also continue impressing upon the administration the importance of having a private room for group work. We say this because, unfortunately, the setting for groups is often very poor—be prepared to deal with terrible spaces for conducting groups.

Other things the leader needs to consider about the setting are whether the room is comfortable, what the wall decorations are like, what the lighting is like, and whether the seating arrangements and chairs are comfortable. Any of these can affect the therapeutic forces. The relative size of the chairs must also be considered. It is best when they are approximately the same size, especially in a counseling/therapy group, because members sitting at various heights may create a negative group dynamic. An option in such a case is to have everyone sit on the floor. The leader would want to do this only if there is a comfortable carpet to sit on and the members agree. More than likely, a leader would not use the floor for education, discussion, or task groups. In most group situations, it is best that the chairs not be lounge chairs because members tend to simply relax and not get involved in the process. Another consideration is whether or not to use tables. In most cases, it is better not to, because tables tend to serve as barriers between members. But there will be times when the leader may want to have tables, particularly in certain education and task groups.

Once these details are taken care of, the leader still has some other factors to consider. Usually the best seating arrangement is a circle, so that all members can see one another. The leader will want to make sure that the vision of all members is free of obstruction so that no one feels excluded. A tighter circle often creates a more intimate feeling, and members may tend to share more.

Time of Day

The time the group meets can be a negative force. If the group meets right after lunch or late in the day, the leader and the members may be tired. When setting up a group, the leader should choose a time that seems best for the majority of those involved. This may seem like a simple matter, but often leaders find themselves leading a group where the members have little energy because of the meeting time.

The Leader's Attitude

The leader's feelings about leading a group definitely affect how the group will go. During workshops on group leadership, it is common to hear group leaders express their inability to control negative members, which results in their disliking the group. If the group contains hostile, nonvoluntary members, the leader should try to find a way to get these members involved; however, if the members are completely resistant and negative, the leader may need to remove them from the group. Otherwise, the leader will end up with a negative attitude regarding the group.

Another possible reason for the leader having a negative attitude is that the leader is being required to lead a group with people he does not like or on a topic in which he has little or no interest. If the leader cannot avoid leading the group and cannot change his feelings about the members or topic, he may try adding a coleader. If that is not possible, the leader should spend extra time planning the sessions in the hope that the exercises and activities will help make the group more interesting for both the members and leader. If the leader does not do this, the group surely will go poorly. If you ever find yourself in this situation, remember that trying to make it interesting is certainly to your advantage.

Closed or Open Groups

An important decision for the leader is whether the membership will be *open* or *closed*. Many groups are conducted as closed groups—that is, no new members are admitted once the group is established. Closed groups can be time limited and goal oriented. Many groups are also conducted on an open basis—members join and leave periodically. The purpose of the group and the population being served usually dictate the leader's choice. In most cases, especially for support and counseling or therapy groups, a closed group is better because the members develop trust and comfort as the group evolves. The only time a closed group becomes a detriment is when the group is getting stale and additional members would add new life.

In some settings, such as hospitals or residential treatment centers where there are new arrivals weekly, groups with an open membership are mandated. This does not have to constitute a negative force if the leader's style is adjusted for this dynamic. The leader must keep in mind that the group will not evolve

through various stages because members will always be at different places in their feelings about the group. When introducing new members, the leader will want to develop methods that do not detract from the flow of the group. A common mistake made by leaders of open groups is to spend too much time introducing and orienting new members, thus creating a negative force.

Voluntary or Nonvoluntary Membership

Perhaps the most basic force to consider is whether the members are voluntary or nonvoluntary. Naturally, it would be nice if all groups could be held on a voluntary basis. However, the courts and settings such as correctional institutions, residential treatment centers, and schools often mandate group participation. When a leader must conduct a group where there are nonvolunteers, it is important to adapt to this dynamic. Both Yalom (2005) and Corey (2012) state that negative attitudes about being in a group can be transformed by the leader's ability to prepare members for the group. Corey further states that the leader also has to *believe* in the group process. Often some nonvoluntary members change their negative attitude if the first couple of sessions go well. To make the first sessions successful, the leader must plan the group on the assumption that there will be negative attitudes. The following are three examples of what a leader might say to nonvoluntary members during the first session.

EXAMPLES

LEADER: I realize many of you do not want to be here and probably are thinking this is going to be a big waste of time. All I can say is that I hope you will at least give it a chance. I think I have some things planned that should be of interest to all of you.

LEADER: Because you did not volunteer for this group, I imagine you may have some strong negative feelings about being here. You will have a chance to air those feelings in a few minutes, but first I want to tell you a little about what we will be doing in the hope that you will see that the group can be interesting and may be helpful to you.

LEADER: Every time I lead one of these groups, there are members who fight being here at the beginning, but by the end they thank me for providing a place for them to share their thoughts and feelings. I know that some of you right now are angry about being forced to be in this group. All I can say is that these sessions have helped some people, and they can help you if you let them. If you will give the group a chance for a couple of weeks, I will do all I can to make it a good experience.

There will be times when, no matter what the leader does, some members remain negative and antitherapeutic. When faced with this situation, the leader should accept that the group will not go as well as desired. It is sometimes a good idea, when possible, to divide the group and let those who are totally negative sit out of the circle of the group and do something else, such as read, rest, or sit quietly. Another strategy is to meet with the entire group for less time and then excuse the negative members and have those who are really interested remain. If you have nonvoluntary members, remember to plan for the negative group dynamics at the beginning of and perhaps throughout the sessions. Planning interesting and creative sessions is essential!

Members' Level of Commitment

One of the forces to consider when thinking about the group is the members' level of commitment. By commitment, we mean desiring to be cooperative rather than resistant, disruptive, or hostile. A group made up of members with commitment will be much easier to lead than one with members who have little or no commitment. Members lacking commitment are those who are forced to attend, as well as those who want to direct the group or be the center of attention. When commitment is low, members tend to get off track, show little interest, contribute very little, display disruptive behavior, argue with the leader, or attack each other. In other words, all kinds of negative group dynamics occur when there is little commitment.

How do you know if there is commitment? One way to assess commitment is to conduct pre-group interviews to gauge where the members are in reference to being a member. If screening is not possible, the best way to assess this is simply to observe your members. You can nearly always tell how they feel about being in the group. If you are not sure, bring the topic up for discussion. Simply ask, "What is your feeling about being in the group?"

Level of Trust

In groups whose members have commitment, trust will usually develop over time if the group is moving in a positive direction. Problems of trust often occur when members have very different points of view. If the group consists of members who do not like each other, the leader can try to change this by bringing it up in the group or by meeting with some members privately to see if their differences can be resolved. The leader may even ask one or more members to drop out of the group. If the lack of trust does not change and, because of administrative policy, the members cannot be asked to leave the group, the leader will have to accept the fact that leading the group will be very difficult.

In counseling or therapy and growth groups, there is always the chance that some members will make some hurtful and judgmental comments to another member after some disclosure of an intimate detail of her life such as an affair, abortion, or sexual orientation. The leader's first concern needs to be for the disclosing member and to show that members will not be attacked for sharing

comments or details of their lives. The leader needs to discuss these critical comments in such a way as to be supportive of the member under attack and, at the same time, not alienate the critical member or members.

■ EXAMPLE

JODI: *(With her head down and in a sad voice)* I don't know how this happened. I didn't think this happened to people in their 50s. I thought only young people had affairs. Karl and I have nothing in common, and now with the kids being off at college, I am lonely. This guy at the place I work started eating lunch with me; and over the last six months, we have shared a lot. One thing led to another; and last week, we spent the afternoon at his place. Now, I feel so guilty and confused.

BUD: Jodi, I can't believe you would do that to your husband! You should have controlled yourself and not been so selfish. What about Karl?! I think ...

LEADER: *(Using a firm but soft voice)* Bud, I want to stay with Jodi and help her with her pain. I want us to try to help her deal with her feelings and not be judgmental about her behavior. That is not what this group is for. Jodi, why don't you say some more and then we'll hear from others. I know that many can understand your feelings. *(Heads nod, indicating they understand)*

■ ■ ■

If the leader allows negative statements to go by without clarification, trust becomes an antitherapeutic force and the members will probably tend not to disclose much personal information for fear of being criticized. Ideally, the leader can address the issue of being judgmental in the group and help members be more open-minded and less critical. Sometimes, leaders get sidetracked and focus on the "judgmental" member or the topic of not being judgmental first instead of focusing on the disclosing member who is in pain.

Members' Attitude Toward the Leader

The attitudes of the members toward the leader have to be considered when leading any group. Do they like him? Do they respect him? Do they trust him? Do they respect his group leadership skills? In most groups, members will have a variety of feelings toward the leader. Sometimes all the members may have negative feelings about the leader. In such a case, the leader needs to examine this dynamic, because it may have something to do with leadership style or ability.

Often only one or two members harbor negative feelings. One person who is out to "get the leader" can definitely interfere with positive group dynamics.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: I would like to take a few minutes to discuss how you are feeling about your progress in reaching the goals you set for yourself.

MELVIN: *(Angrily)* Why do you always ask us that? Let's do something different. This isn't helpful.

In this situation, the leader would not want to focus on the negative member, especially if she knows that the member is mainly out to "get" her. The leader can deflect the negative dynamic by saying, in a soft, firm voice, something like this:

LEADER: Melvin, I think most find this helpful and a way to think about their goals. *(Turning to the rest of the group)* How are all of you feeling about your progress?

■ ■ ■

The most important thing for leaders to realize is that negative attitudes about them as leaders definitely affect the interaction and disclosures in the group.

The Leader's Experience in Leading Groups

For those who are just starting out, the therapeutic force of experience needs to be mentioned. A beginning leader may be an antitherapeutic force because the leader lacks skills, may be nervous, and will make mistakes. If the leader is nervous, it is important to recognize this and, if need be, mention it to the group. Along these same lines, in a counseling or therapy group, an antitherapeutic force will be present if the leader does not have much individual counseling experience. For a good therapy group to occur, the leader must be experienced in individual counseling and have knowledge about counseling theories.

Ideally, beginning leaders would work with a more experienced coleader for a few groups before leading by themselves. If you find yourself leading without the benefit of prior experience, do the best you can and learn from the experience by discussing your group with your supervisor or colleague.

Coleadership Harmony

Coleading can be a very positive or negative force when leading a group. If the two leaders are in sync with each other, then it is almost always a positive force. When the leaders view group leading in two different ways, then coleading can serve as an antitherapeutic force. In Chapter 6, we discuss in detail the pros and cons of coleading.

Process and Content

We, along with Corey, Corey, and Corey (2014), Geroski and Kraus (2002), Gladding (2012), and many other writers, stress the importance of paying attention to the group process. Posthuma (2002); Hulse-Killacky, Kraus, and Schumacher

(1999); and Sonstegard and Bitter (2004) discuss the need for balancing *process* and *content*. The term *process* includes stages of group, group dynamics, and therapeutic forces. *Content* refers to the purpose or task of the group. The leader always needs to be aware of both the content and process and focus the group on each, depending on the purpose and what is needed at the time. Hulse-Killacky and colleagues (1999) state, "process and content are mutually interactive and operate as two threads of one string" (p. 117). Geroski and Kraus (2002) found in their study of psychoeducation groups that experienced group workers were unable to agree on what constitutes process and content in the specific groups studied.

Leaders make mistakes when it comes to how much emphasis should be placed on process and content. Some put too much importance on content and some put too much importance on process. Some leaders focus so much on what is going on and making sure everyone speaks that the group never achieves any meaningful depth. Other leaders focus so much on individual counseling that they miss the tremendous value of members interacting and hearing from others and struggling at times with relationships within the group. *The skilled leader is always monitoring the content and the process during any session.*



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Process and Content

Watch videos 2.1 and 2.2. You will hear a discussion of the balance of content and process and see the leader focusing on process in 2.1, and balancing between content and process on 2.2.

Concluding Comments

In this chapter, we discussed the stages of groups, group process, and therapeutic forces that leaders must be aware of to be effective. All groups go through at least three stages: beginning, working, and closing. Some groups will go through additional stages. It is important that leaders be aware that groups go through these stages even though the amount of time for each stage depends on the kind of group and its purpose. *Group process* (also called *group dynamics*) refers to the attitudes and interaction of members and leaders. It is also important for the leader to be aware of both *process* and *content* during any session. *Therapeutic forces* are the many different elements operating in a group, such as its size, its setting, the time of day it meets, its member composition, the trust and commitment levels of its members, and its leader's attitude and experience.

ACTIVITIES

- Think back on groups you have either been in or led, and think about mistakes that were made in each of the three stages of the group.

- Think of two groups that you led or were a member of that were not successful. Now look over our list of the 15 therapeutic forces and mark which ones were antitherapeutic for each of the two groups. Consider what you or the leader could have done differently to change the antitherapeutic forces to make them more therapeutic.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. Review video 2.1.
   a. Think about the importance of the leader being aware of both content and process.
   b. What would have happened if the leader would have just stayed with the content and had the members get into pairs?
2. Review video 2.2.
   a. Why did the leader need to think about both content and process?
3. Review the first video—The Leader Without Skills (1.1).
   a. What group dynamics do you see between members?

Web Sites

If you are interested in specific literature on group dynamics, you may want to check out the APA journal *Group Dynamics: Theory, Research, and Practice* (www.apa.org).

You may also want to do an Internet search of the term "group dynamics" and visit some of the sites that seem most interesting to you.